My Brother's Funerals

(from The Redhead and the Slaughter King)

By Megan Falley

An Apology To My Brother

I'm sorry I spill your secrets / like an overfull goblet of wine.

I'm sorry I think they're *mine mine mine.*

I'm sorry that I love you / the way a shadow loves its body-

that I always sniff your hair.

I'm sorry that in the poems I name you *Needle.* / In the poems I name you *Pill.*

I'm sorry it's always *recovering,* never *recovered.*

That I'm still nervous when you call.

That I think it's for bail.

I'm sorry that when you say *I love you,* I wait for the *but,*

I'm sorry I always write about you as if you are dead.

It's just-

I spent so many years preparing for that funeral.

All my dresses are black.

INTRODUCTION

It has taken me a long, long time to come to the realization that when the person you love becomes an addict, they are no longer the person you love. You can spend your nights trying to understand addiction, and how somebody can transform into a person so horrific right before your own eyes, but there is no understanding it.

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Golden Boy

My brother's hair looked like someone cooked a porridge comprised entirely of sunshine and poured the bowl over his head. It was a yellow traffic light that everyone slowed down for.

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They complimented my mother, told her she was *lucky.* He was a dandelion of a boy . . . but when we picked him up after his first day of High School- he demanded we take him to the barbershop.

This memory comes before heroin became a household name. Before I found my piggybank slaughtered -- my brother's mouth filled with more pills than teeth.

He slammed the door as he stormed into the $7 barber.

Alone, he growled.

I was six years old and did not know what this meant, but I saw my mother's eyes in the rearview mirror -- she knew what happened when dandelion boys asked for the lawnmower.

He returned to the passenger side years older than he was when he left it, switched the channel on the radio to something harder, faster, twisted the volume knob up to drown the words no one was speaking.

Back in the barbershop, someone swept up that gold-spun miracle and threw it away.

My mother knew a war was going to come, the way animals know before rain. The way they know, but can do nothing to stop it.

TRANSITION

And so I began to prepare, to plan his funeral. I wrote eulogy after eulogy, trying to find a way to deal with the ultimate oblivion of my brother's death.

The First Ceremony

If I was the family florist, I'd be responsible for the apology of lilies.

If I was the lawyer, I'd be expected to pay for it all -- the party of black.

If I was the chef, they'd ask me to feed those who cannot imagine eating.

But I am the writer -- not the star of the funeral, but its narrator -- here to translate the language of grief into simple, digestible metaphor.

To wield euphemisms.

Turn *addiction* into *grip on reality.*

Turn *overdose* into *sudden, unfair.*

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My mother can melt like a satin witch into her corner of the pew, my father can do what men do: prove his strength, become a pallbearer. But I'm the emcee at my brother's last big party -- so I recite his eulogy to shampoo bottles, haven't sung in the shower for years.

My brother bangs on the bathroom door, says, *Hurry up - [what's] taking so long?*

I do hurry up.

I want him to love me.

There's still dirt on my skin, though. There's still soap in my hair.

TRANSITION

Or maybe Sean's funeral will be like this . . .

The Second Ceremony

We bury him with his baseball cards because that's what he has left, what his life amounted to.

The electronics sold. The house turned to soot at the whim of one cigarette.

Even the girls figured him out.

We bury him with his friends outside the funeral home, too scared to enter, sweating like burned spoons.

We replace his face in its forever bed with each of theirs, their pockmarked arms and rotted smiles.

We bargain with the god of too late.

We bury him in his father's suit, which was too big for him before and ridiculous now, but nobody buys a new suit for the dead.

We leave him to lie in his potential.

I bury him with a picture of me. Don't bother to tape the jagged, toothy edge back together. He ripped himself out on purpose -- and look how I'm smiling in the photo. Look how I'm leaning on nothing.

TRANSITION

The images get bleaker and bleaker as Sean's addiction worsens . . .

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The Third Ceremony

I am the only one at your funeral.

I fill the vase with the right flowers and press my face into them, but only smell your cigarettes.

I recite the obituary that I've been saving for this occasion ever since the summer you started putting fireflies on your tongue and winning contests for cruelest hands.

I admit, it's a flawless performance, gifted to an empty room, but I can't help but hate you for not cracking an embalmed smirk during the funny parts.

I carry your casket alone which is also an exercise I've been training for.

The hearse is the only one waiting for me to finish.

There will be no procession, no cars following behind. You've left no shadow.

Pawned all the people who could have been here for highs even you knew weren't worth it.

I am relieved -- the worst is over. I received the phone call, confirmed your body. I open a black umbrella, blame you for the rain.

TRANSITION

And then there's a ray of hope . . . Rehab seems to be working and images of Sean's funeral shift again to the way it should be . . . the way I hope it will be. My mind whispers "Please, Sean . . . let rehab work this time."

The Last Ceremony

The widest church in town is still too small to fit everyone who has loved you through its heavy doors, so we hold two funerals.

No one wears black.

We wear your sports jerseys from high school. We wear the t-shirts you collected from the marathons you ran to raise awareness for addiction.

Your grandchildren wear the sheets from the forts you built with them, cut into capes.

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Your wife does not cry, she feels lucky to have loved you.

You live on in every wrinkle.

You gave her those smile lines she wears like jewelry.

The men from the meetings tell stories about you saving them, yanking them from their own syringes and vomit, they name their kids after you.

There are so many boys named Sean,

Sean.

I wish our father was here to see this, but maybe he's waiting up there with a catcher's mitt, maybe there's a baseball whizzing through the air for you.

I know you'll catch it.

In the casket, you are older than rain, just as exquisite.

There is not a shadow of pain on your face.

You learned the science of turning it to joy.

I remember the day, decades ago, when you told me I was your best friend.

I could have died right then, but we were given the gift of years, and dinners, and holidays, and children, and forgiveness which is sweeter than any liquor.

This is the first of your funerals where no one asks me to make the speech.

I just sit in the front row and weep, and am not sad.

I am the least sad I have ever been.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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